We Rise, We Resist, We Raise our Voices

Wade and Cheryl Willis Hudson (eds)

What Shall We Tell You? by Wade Hudson (Pg 4)

What shall we tell you when our world sometimes seems dark and uninviting?

What shall we tell you when hateful words that wound and bully are thrown like bricks against a wall, shattering into debris?

What shall we tell you when respect for others and treating others as we wish to be treated appear as yesterday's borrowed wish?

What shall we tell you when our differences are juggled like fragile eggs that could be smashed at a moment impulse?

What shall we tell you? What shall we tell you?

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We shall tell you that love, like cream in milk, will rise to the top and hatred and distrust will be revealed as imposters.

We shall tell you that peace, desirable like a restful night after a long day at play, is not far away. Reach for it.

We shall tell you that respect for others, like a delicious ice cream bar dripping on holding fingers, tastes better than contempt.

We shall tell you that we love you, all of you! And because we love you, we will be there to help bring light to dark places.

We will be there with peace and justice as our weapons and love as a soothing salve to comfort and embrace.

We shall tell you that because we will be there for you, always be there for you, it will be all right! It will be all right!

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INTRODUCTION

Hope is what remains when the lights go out and the levees break, when institutions crumble, when all the exits are blocked and we become lost children waiting for a savior who may never come. Hope is what whispers (whisper) "things can change." Something better is waiting if we just have the courage to hold on.

It is hard not to cling to hope these days, to wish for a world that feels safer, fairer and kinder. We want to believe our actions matter; that we can nudge the world, however slightly, toward more freedom, opportunity, equality, love and joy.

And yet, when we look back at how far we've come, it is difficult not to wonder if anything has truly changed. Some days it feels like we are falling back decades, even centuries, into our cruelest and most paranoid past. Do you have hope that things can change?

Poetry from We Rise, We Resist, We Raise our Voices edited by Wade and Cherly Willis Hudson

Drumbeat for Change by Kelly Starling Lyons (Pg 30)

This world feels upside down sometimes,

like a twisted house of mirrors where

people in charge are bullies,

where protestors of racism are pummeled,

where being who you are can put your life on the line.

What do we do with the worry, the hurt, the rage?

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We turn it into something bigger than us.

We turn it into change.

Together, we are a mountain no one can destroy.

Having faith doesn't mean we are fearless.

It means we believe and press on

Toward love.

Toward equality.

Toward a safer, stronger future.

We press on and stay true to what we know is right.

Throughout history, kids like you were right there.

With picket signs and petitions.

With heart and humility.

With bravery and brilliance.

They changed this world for the better.

And you will too.

Tell your story.

To anyone who will listen.

To hear it yourself.

You matter.

You ***matter.***

You. Matter.

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The drumbeat of hope will always drown out howls of hate . . .

When you feel angry or afraid, remember what you hold inside.
Kindness.
Courage.
Compassion.
The power of people who made a way out of no way.
Who persevered and toppled injustice.

March to that drumbeat of hope.
March and know you are never alone.
Standing up and speaking out,
pressing for justice,
having each other's backs,
we will create change.

Where are the Good People? by Tameka Fryer Brown (Pg 56-57)

Life's not always fair and sometimes it's scary.
When safe spaces aren't safe,
when protectors harm us,

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when leaders try to lead us toward fear and hate,
there's nothing fair or reassuring about that.

Maybe it would be helpful to know
these aren't the first troubling times
our world has seen,
that none has ever lasted forever.

Tyrants rise and fall;
bad guys win, then lose;
evil gets overtaken by good
when good people stand together against it.

Who and where are the good people?

They're all around us every day
telling truths, seeking justice, persisting.
They are the helpers, the listeners,
the lovers of everyone.

Changemakers – that's what they'll call us
tomorrows from now
if you and I fight for fairness starting today.
Do you believe that we can?
I do too. Action is power . . .

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A Talkin'-To by Jason Reynolds (Pg 75)

I could tell you all the bad things,
all the bad things that cut and scare
and howl and growl and gnash and
bear teeth, bright and sharp that
glint in the moonlight.

I could tell you all that's frightening,
all that's frightening and lurking
and looming and hiding in the brush,
razor-hair pricked up on the back
of something too sly to see.

I could tell you about all the loud things,
all the loud things that scream
and shriek and shred our ability to hear
each other, the beasts behind screens,
Scrolling banners of bully-banter.

I could tell you all the things,
all the things that are trying to tell you
how you should run,
but I am about you above all things,
so I'd rather tell you one thing and one thing only:

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Everything bad and frightening and loud
will always hide when you hold your head up,
will always hid when you hold your heart out,
will always sing a shrinking song
when you fly.

Drumbeat for Change by Kelly Starling Lyons (Pg 30)

(Refrain) This world feels upside down sometimes,
like a twisted house of mirrors where
people in charge are bullies,
where protestors of racism are pummeled,
where being who you are can put your life on the line.
What do we do with the worry, the hurt, the rage?
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We turn it into change.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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